

CLIMATE SMART COMMUNITIES

Breakout Session Summary

Westchester Clean Energy Action Conference



This breakout session brought together municipal officials, developers, housing operators, and energy professionals for a candid, ground-level conversation about what it actually takes to build climate-smart communities. The discussion ranged from zoning strategy and affordable housing finance to building systems, workforce training, and the persistent challenge of community opposition.

SESSION PARTICIPANTS

Moderator	 Richard D. Ross Director of Housing Development HANAC, Inc.	 Adam Salgado Commissioner of Development City of New Rochelle
	 Joe Apicella Executive VP MacQuesten Development	 Gibson Craig Director of Design and Sustainability Wilder Balter
	 Dave Work Vice President of Customer Project Delivery NYPA	

1. ZONING AS A CLIMATE TOOL

Adam Salgado framed New Rochelle's approach as a decade-long effort to embed sustainability directly into the zoning code rather than treating it as an add-on. Key mechanisms include:

- A sustainability checklist built into zoning approvals, so developers must meet a baseline standard to qualify for density or other benefits.
- A community benefit bonus that drives green infrastructure investment around buildings, sold to residents as a way to deliver public realm improvements and amenities.
- Green infrastructure exemptions from developer fees when tied to public realm improvements.
- A green technology workforce program in development, with the city open to providing deeper technical incentives to developers who go further.

"Programs are only ever gonna be novel. They're never gonna have scale if they're not underwritten by the private sector."

Adam Salgado, Commissioner of Development, City of New Rochelle

His core argument: without private sector buy-in at the underwriting level, clean energy programs will remain one-off experiments rather than standard practice. New Rochelle's role is to create the framework that makes private investment the default, not the exception.

2. AFFORDABLE HOUSING AND SUSTAINABILITY FINANCING

A significant thread centered on stacking financing sources to make sustainable affordable housing work financially. Examples from the session included affordable condominiums made possible by layering AHOP financing with IDA support, and a 103-unit senior building in Story Creek that competed for and won \$3 million in additional sustainability funds. The takeaway: grant money exists, but capturing it requires research, due diligence, and the ability to write competitive applications.

"We actually won that money. That was a huge benefit."

Richard D. Ross, Director of Housing Development, HANAC, Inc.

The housing demand backdrop was stark. One panelist referenced a Brooklyn affordable housing project that received 60,000 applicants. The consensus: sustainability and affordability have to be solved together, not sequentially.

3. BUILDING SYSTEMS: GEOTHERMAL, HEAT PUMPS & FUTURE-PROOFING

Geothermal

One panelist described a geothermal installation in a senior housing building with results that exceeded expectations. Scale is critical: at 45 to 50 units, you cannot build in redundancy and end up with oversized pumps and no backup. Larger projects get much better economics. Retrofitting existing buildings also requires managing resident expectations carefully.

"We see more savings. We were hesitant to get involved. You don't know until you do it."

Joe Apicella, Executive VP, MacQuesten Development

Future-Proofing

One panelist pushed hard on sizing infrastructure for future needs, not just current ones. The same logic applies to EV charging: install panel capacity now so you are not starting behind the curve when demand management software or additional chargers are needed.

"Is the pad big enough? Do we have the right pipe? We might not need the tonnage now, but we're sure gonna wish we did."

Dave Work, VP of Customer Project Delivery, NYPA

Retrocommissioning

The strongest consensus point of the session: before spending capital on new equipment, buildings should retrocommission what they already have. Many facilities are unconsciously optimized for avoiding complaints rather than actual efficiency. A 30-degree corridor losing heat daily was cited as money going out the window simply because a building management system was never set to reset daily.

"The best thing you can do today on a facility is retrocommission what you've got and get it operating properly."

Dave Work, VP of Customer Project Delivery, NYPA

4. ASSET MANAGEMENT AND OPERATIONS

Proactive asset management emerged as a major theme — specifically the gap between capital investment in new systems and the operational capacity to run them. A utility representative noted that enterprise-scale asset management tools can now be applied at the level of a single residential building. The goal is to replace the pump before the red light goes off, not during a Sunday morning emergency. A recurring frustration: property managers overseeing seven to ten buildings often lack the support to properly operate new energy systems, and incentive structures do not always reward energy performance.

Workforce Training

A sharp exchange about building service workers (32BJ) and whether they are actually equipped to operate new energy systems. With the union contract coming up, one speaker suggested negotiating energy system training into the new agreement.

"I put in some of these new systems. The other problem is 32BJ knowing how to use it."

5. COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT AND OPPOSITION

The final and most animated part of the session dealt with community opposition. One speaker called it the elephant in the room: communities are not just dismissing clean energy investment but, in some cases, punishing those who address it.

Structural Obstacles

- People who want to stop development will find another way even after projects clear regulatory hurdles. One speaker described clearing CEQA without trouble and still fighting approvals five years later.
- Vocal opponents dominate public hearings while the silent majority — often the seniors and families who most need the housing — do not show up.
- Political transitions extend timelines so that the officials who initiated a project are no longer in office by the time it comes up for approval. The new group starts from opposition.

“It took so long to get the approvals, the council and the mayor who initiated the project were gone. The new group comes in, and they’re fighting us.”

Joe Apicella, Executive VP, MacQuesten Development

What Works

One speaker’s approach: go beyond public hearings with direct community outreach, introducing the project team personally and making them accessible throughout construction. Even then, it does not always work. For high-visibility projects, thousands of direct touchpoints may be necessary — not just formal comment periods.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1

Sustainability has to be baked into zoning and financing structures. If it depends on individual program funding cycles, it will not scale.

2

Affordable housing and clean energy are the same problem. Solving them separately is not working.

3

The best near-term investment for most buildings is retrocommissioning existing systems before buying new equipment.

4

Future-proofing decisions (panels, pads, pipe sizing) are cheap upfront and very expensive to fix later.

5

Geothermal works and surprises on the upside, but scale and redundancy matter significantly.

6

Operations and training are the missing piece. Capital investments underperform when building staff cannot operate the systems.

7

Community opposition is structural, not just communicational. Political transitions, slow timelines, and vocal minorities require sustained, proactive engagement.